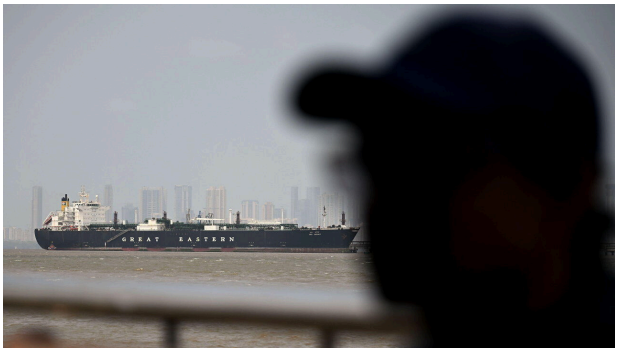
The world in brief

Catch up quickly on the global stories that matter



Photograph: Alamy

Iran said that the **Strait of Hormuz** was “completely open” to commercial ships, as a result of a ten-day ceasefire between Israel and Lebanon coming into effect. Donald Trump also posted on social media that the strait was “FULLY OPEN”, and added that America’s blockade of ships linked to Iran in the strait remains. It remains to be seen whether other vessels will begin to pass through. Brent crude, the oil benchmark, fell by more than 5%, to below $90 per barrel.

Mr Trump urged **Hizbullah**, the Iran-backed militia that has been the target of Israeli attacks in Lebanon, to act “nicely” during the ceasefire. One of Hizbullah’s senior lawmakers suggested the success of the truce depended on Israel halting all hostilities. Hawks within Israel, including from Mr Netanyahu’s **Likud** party, criticised the deal. One called the idea of the “state of Lebanon” a “fiction”.

In an apparent reference to **Iran’s** stockpile of highly enriched uranium, Mr Trump said the country had “agreed to give us back the nuclear dust”, though he gave no details. The fate of the estimated 400kg of near-weapons-grade material has been a

sticking point in talks. Iran offered no comment. The president also said that the countries were “very close to making a deal”.

OnlyFans is set to sell a minority stake to **Architect Capital,** an American investor, in a deal which values the company at more than $3bn. The platform, which is best known for its adult content, has sought investment recently, a process made harder by the death of its owner last month. The partnership is expected to help the site’s content creators access banking services more easily.

Reed Hastings, the co-founder of **Netflix**, plans to step down from the streaming platform’s board in June. The firm said Mr Hastings wanted to focus on “philanthropy and other pursuits”. Its shares fell by 9.6% following the announcement, despite strong first-quarter results. Netflix reported a profit of $5.3bn, boosted by the $2.8bn it received from Paramount after a deal to purchase Warner Bros fell through.

Uber increased its stake in **Delivery Hero**, a food-delivery company, in a deal worth €270m ($318m). The shares are being sold by Prosus, the German firm’s largest shareholder, to comply with the **European Commission’s** competition rules after it bought Just Eat, another food-delivery firm, last year. Uber has pledged to expand into seven new European markets, targeting $1bn in additional revenue.

Myanmar’s president, Min Aung Hlaing, who seized power in a coup in 2021, released over 4,000 prisoners as part of a broad amnesty to mark the country’s Thingyan new year. He also commuted all death sentences to life imprisonment. The former president, Win Myint, was pardoned, while Aung San Suu Kyi, who had ruled alongside him, had her sentence reduced by nearly five years.

Figure of the day: $25bn, the value of oil and gas infrastructure destroyed in the Gulf since the war in Iran began. Explore how the

conflict is clouding the investment outlook of the region’s sovereign wealth funds.

Photograph: AFP

Lebanon on edge

Celebratory gunfire rang out above Beirut as a ceasefire between Israel and Hizbulla came into effect after nearly six weeks of fighting. The truce gives Lebanon's government ten days to take meaningful steps to disarm the Iran-backed militant group. It also calls for negotiations on a border agreement between Israel and Lebanon. Hizbullah acknowledged the truce, which it credited Iran with brokering.

Donald Trump announced the agreement, and America's State Department published the details. Much remains unclear: the deal makes no mention of an Israeli withdrawal from Lebanon (Israel says its army will remain in the south), and allows Israel the right to strike targets in Lebanon "in self-defence, at any time". Despite the uncertainty, within moments of the ceasefire taking hold, roads south of Lebanon's capital filled with people attempting to return home. More than a million were displaced as Israel razed several villages along the border, and killed over 2,000 in strikes.

Photograph: Alamy

Decision day at SCOTUS

By next month, after America's Supreme Court hears the final nine oral arguments of its term, the justices will be glued to their keyboards writing opinions for three dozen cases. But at least one decision is due on Friday morning.

The court never says which. But a single case remains from its October sitting: *Louisiana v Callais*, a clash over the Voting Rights Act of 1965. Part of the VRA forbids rejigging electoral maps to dilute minorities' voting power. After the 2020 census, though, Louisiana did just that. Black voters held a majority in just one of six districts, despite making up one-third of the state's electorate. When a court ordered the addition of a second district with a black majority, a group of non-African-American voters claimed the fix violated the constitution's equal-protection clause. If SCOTUS upholds that ruling, it will be the VRA's second major setback since 2013, when the court removed a separate protection against voting discrimination.

Photograph: Getty Images

Britain and France lead a defensive Hormuz mission

Sir Keir Starmer, Britain's prime minister, travelled to Paris on Friday as part of Franco-British efforts to organise a freedom-of-navigation mission in the Strait of Hormuz. Sir Keir and Emmanuel Macron, France's president, will host a mostly virtual meeting with representatives from around 30 other countries that have remained neutral in the conflict in the Middle East. The idea, say the French, is that this ad hoc coalition could carry out a "strictly defensive" operation to ensure safe passage for civilian vessels through the waterway. It would begin only when the fighting dies down.

In recent weeks there have been disagreements about what such a mission should look like in practice. France thinks that only "non-belligerent" countries should take part; Britain wanted American involvement to offset the military risks. But Sir Keir seems to have shifted position after America ordered a blockade of Iranian ports. Without a permanent ceasefire, however, the initiative remains more diplomatic than operational.

IRAN
IRAQ
KUWAIT
Kharg Island
250 km
The Gulf
Strait of Hormuz
BAHRAIN
QATAR
Riyadh
Gulf of Oman
UAE
SAUDI ARABIA
OMAN
Iranian ports
Iran's territorial waters
Sources: IMF PortWatch; UN; Marine Regions

Photograph: dpa

Europe’s trade fix

Europe is grappling with higher energy prices again. A boost from global trade could help its economy weather the storm. On Friday Eurostat, the EU’s statistics bureau, reported a goods trade surplus of €11.5bn ($13.5bn) for the euro area in February, compared with a deficit of €1bn in January. The shift was mostly driven by the machinery and vehicles sector, where the surplus rose from €1.5bn to €10.2bn. Worldwide, goods trade has been growing by about 7% over the last four quarters, compared to the preceding four, according to the UN figures.

Yet the recovery is fragile. The euro area’s surplus is far lower than it was this time last year, when it was €23.1bn. The chemicals sector has taken the largest hit; its surplus fell to €16.2bn in February, down from €30.4bn a year earlier. Trade with its neighbours has also declined. European trade may have turned a corner but the road ahead remains precarious.

Photograph: Getty Images

The NBA courts Europe

The National Basketball Association, a North American juggernaut, is determined to go global. In 2019 it co-founded the Basketball Africa League, a continental competition. Now the NBA is coming to Europe. It is seeking investors to launch new teams in European cities such as London, Paris and Milan. The NBA is also courting teams who compete in the EuroLeague, a 68-year-old tournament whose final round of regular-season games takes place on Friday.

EuroLeague executives are wary. The teams are more open-minded: Real Madrid (a sports club better known for its football team) is holding out on renewing with EuroLeague for another season. A range of outcomes is possible. EuroLeague could succeed in locking in its existing members, denting the NBA's ambitions; the NBA and EuroLeague could merge; or the status and money of the NBA could see teams defect. Expect plenty of action off the court.

Illustration: Sandra Navarro

Daily quiz

We will serve you a new question each weekday. On Friday your challenge is to give us all five answers and tell us the theme. Email your responses (and your home city and country) by 1700 GMT on Friday to . We'll pick three winners at random and crown them on Saturday.

Friday: Which Greek poet is generally credited as the writer of the Iliad and the Odyssey?

Thursday: Which famous painting was stolen from the Louvre in 1911 and not returned until 1914?

Love your enemies, for they tell you your faults.

Benjamin Franklin